renowned design labels and features pieces that have been lent by the likes of the Metropolitan Museum of Art, Coco Chanel and the Musée Yves Saint Laurent Paris, to name a few.

"We hope to showcase the best of India to the world and bring the best of the world to our home," Ambani's daughter, Isha, said at the launch. It is a key component of the Centre's programming philosophy. In a walkthrough, an NMACC representative, who has been in charge of putting together the organisation's structure and leadership as well as lending advice on programming, said the mission is to "groom emerging artists and [focus on] arts education", as also to "showcase the breadth of the Indian culture by supporting artists from small villages to metros". Also prioritised are school and college outreach initiatives and artist residency programmes. "It's not just another space that somebody books and puts up whatever they want," he said. "I have tried to make something using the ideas and thoughts of the design that I have learned from the West but to ensure that it responds to Indian culture."

Designed by the Atlanta-based firm TVS Design, the Centre's three auditoriums align with this mission. Architect Richard Gluckman is behind The Art House, which will host the finest art exhibits and installations from India and abroad, and currently has an exhibit called 'Sangam/Confluence'. The Cube and Studio Theatre are intimate spaces that the representative said cater to "cutting-edge performances" and "artists trying something new". Similarly, the Grand Theatre has been developed to host, as the name suggests, larger-than-life shows, including those from Broadway and the West End. Inspired by the Dolby Theatre in Los Angeles, which is home to the Oscar awards, it has India's biggest proscenium and a Dolby sound system. It also has 18 'diamond' boxes, the most exclusive seats in the theatre, where patrons get an ensuite, private powder room and a specially curated food menu. The theatre's stand-out feature, per TVS Design, is its remarkable Austrian-made ceiling—"17 lotus petals with arabesque perforated pattern"—which is studded with 8,400 Swarovski crystals.





ALL THINGS FINE
1. Yayoi Kusama's installation 'Clouds'
2. The 'Hippie Trail' section of the *India in Fashion* exhibition

The Ambanis are not the first business family in India to invest in a performing arts space. JRD Tata and Jamshed Bhabha were the pioneering forces behind the still-thriving National Centre for the Performing Arts (NCPA) in Mumbai; the Birla Matoshree Sabhagraha in the city, built by Rameshwar Das Birla, is one of the earliest performance spaces; the Anand Mahindra Group has helmed many cultural initiatives, including META (Mahindra Excellence in Theatre Awards), a blues festival and, more recently, a percussion one; and the Godrej Group until 2020 funded the India Culture Lab, which, unfortunately, shut down during the Covid-19 pandemic. By channelling their wealth into an artistic venture, the Ambanis now join a legion of business families who see art as a means to strengthen their legacy.

For Nita Ambani, "India's intangible national wealth" is its "artistic and cultural heritage". And she very well understands the transformative power of art, be it a painting, an image or an embroidered dress. "May art continue to inspire and empower every child and the coming generations, giving them the opportunity to celebrate their creativity, their choices, their differences, their hopes, and their dreams," she said at the launch. Coming from an esteemed business family, it is music to the ears for the artistic fraternity. ■